

FIFA World Cup 2022 Player Analysis

Antoine Griezmann



Team: France | **Position:** Attacking Midfield | **Footed:** Left

Matches Played: 7 | **Starts:** 6 | **Minutes:** 537

Created by Ash Tripathi
[Soccermatics Pro \(2026\)](#)

twelve¹²

Hypothesis

At the 2022 World Cup, Didier Deschamps redeployed **Antoine Griezmann** from his familiar forward role into a deeper, creative midfield position. Griezmann's value in this role was as France's chief creator of high value chances a player who turned possession into shooting opportunities rather than as a goalscorer.

Executive Summary

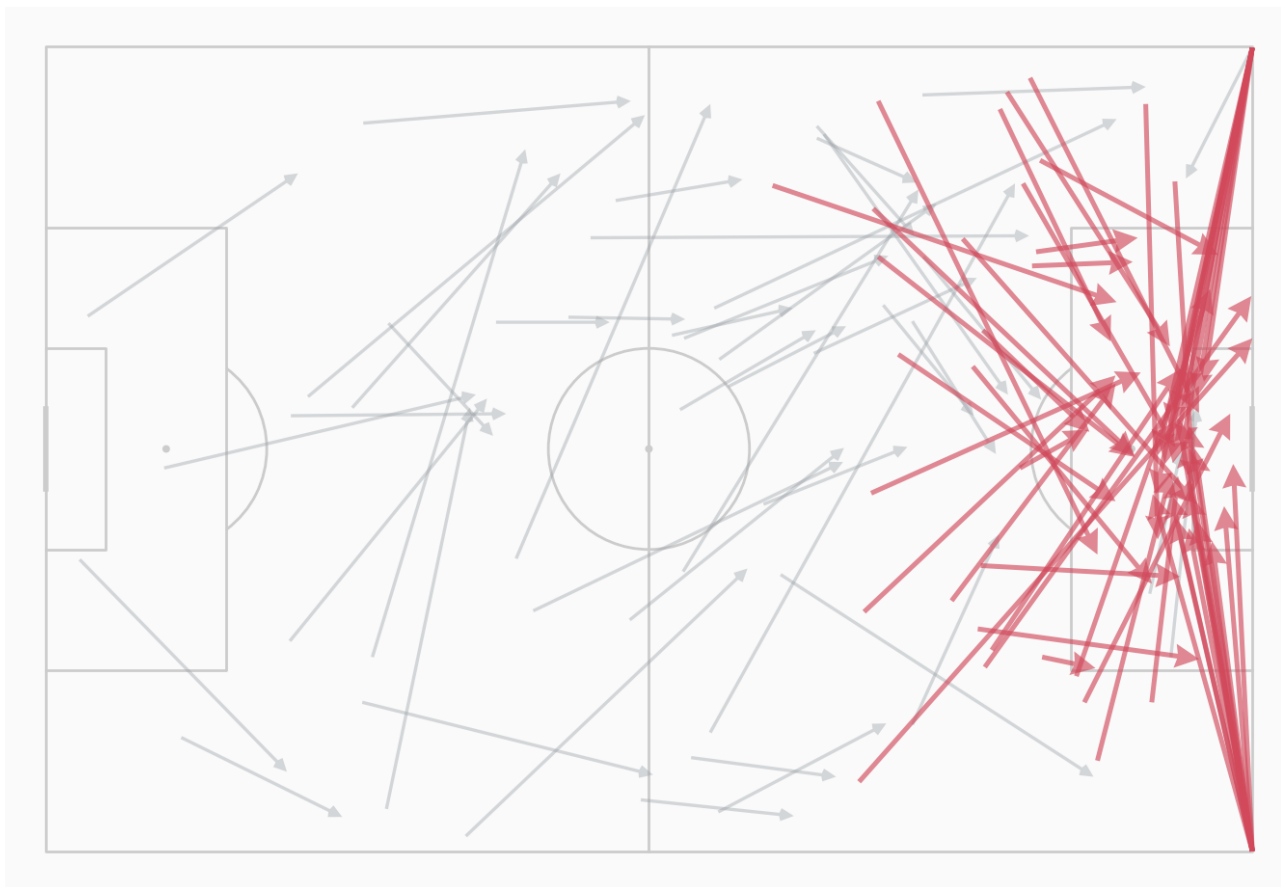
The data strongly supports the hypothesis. Playing as a central attacking midfielder across France's run to the final, **Griezmann was the single most productive chance creator among the 44 players in his role at the tournament**. His expected assists of 0.39 per 90 ranked 1st of 44 (the 100th percentile) meaning no comparable player generated more shooting value from their passing.

He delivered 8.4 passes into the box per 90 (98th percentile), and those deliveries translated directly into chances rather than hopeful balls which is precisely what his expected assists confirms. He paired this with strong ball progression (98th percentile for progressive passes) and an above-average pressing load (89th percentile), making him a complete creative presence, not a one-dimensional one.

His goalscoring was modest, but that was not his function. Griezmann's role was to manufacture France's best chances and, on the evidence, he did so better than any player doing the same job. **He is best deployed between the lines as the team's creative fulcrum, feeding the box and setting up the finishers around him.**

Griezmann repeatedly delivered the ball into the box

Attacking left to right. Box entries (red) are the highest value deliveries.



→ Progressive pass (46) → Pass into box (54)

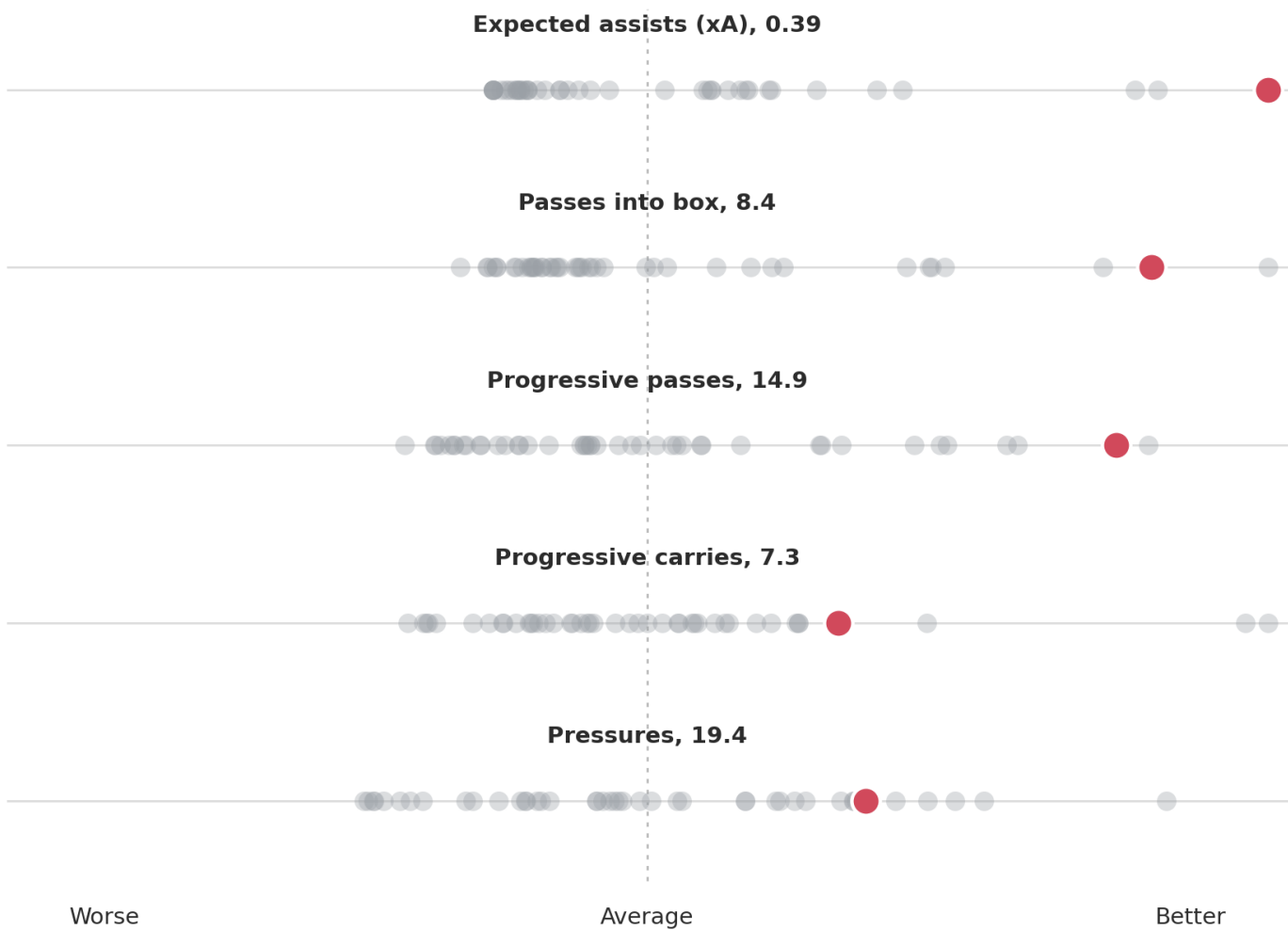
Griezmann was France's release valve into the box, not their engine of progression, but their final ball.

France did not ask Griezmann to build their attacks; they asked him to finish building them. Dropping from the front line into the space between the opposition midfield and defense, he received possession that others had already advanced and turned it into penetration.

The pass map makes the pattern unmistakable: his progressive passes (grey) are scattered and ordinary in volume, but his entries into the penalty area (red) cluster densely from the right half-space and the top of the box, the zones a coach wants a creator operating in.

This is not a player who circulates; it is a player who arrives at the edge of the area and delivers

Griezmann vs every player in the same role



Grey dots: the 44 attacking midfielders and second strikers with 200+ minutes. Red: Griezmann.

Darker patches mean more players at that level. Number after each label is Griezmann's per-90 figure.

Griezmann was France's chance-maker and the best in his position at the whole tournament. Each row compares Griezmann (red) to every other attacking midfielder at the World Cup (grey). The further right the dot, the better.

Creating chances (the standout)
When it came to setting up shooting opportunities for teammates, Griezmann was out on his own further right than every single player in his position. No one in his role created more good chances. This is the heart of his game.

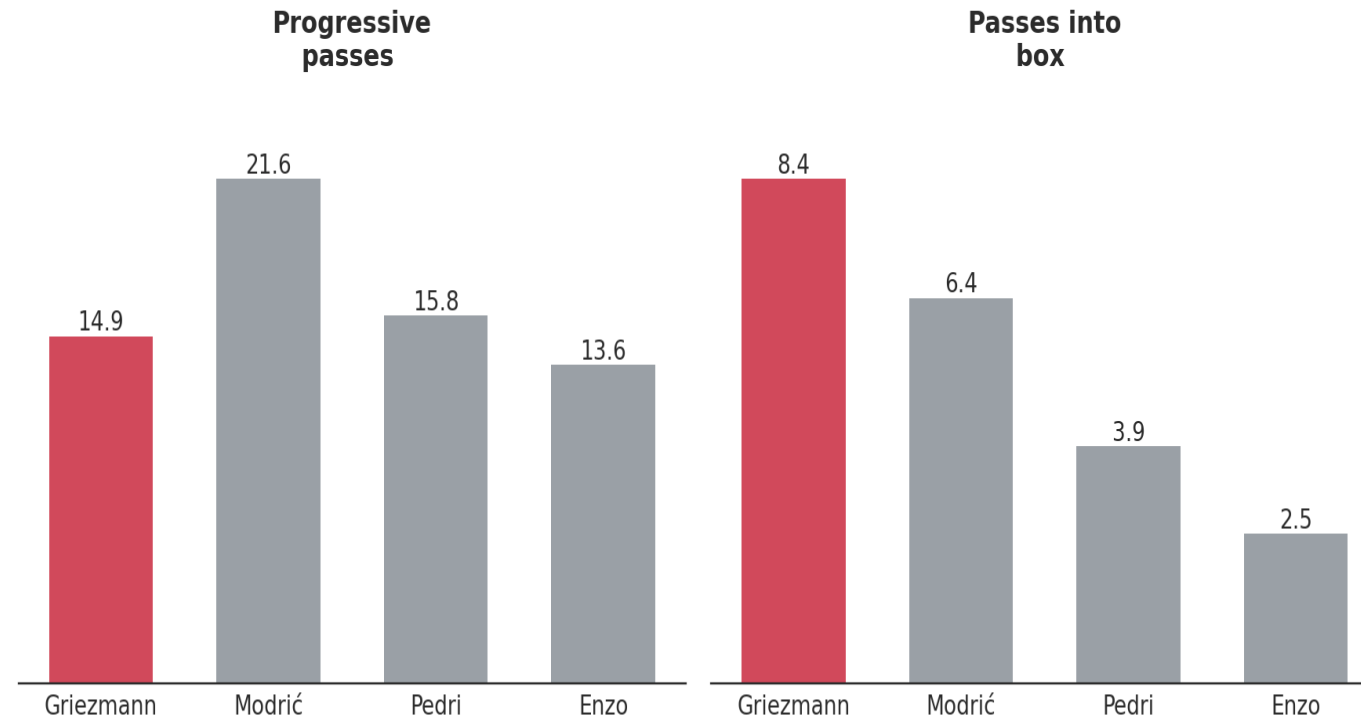
Passes into the box
He played the ball into the danger area more than almost anyone, and as the top row proves those weren't hopeful balls. They turned into real chances.

Driving play forward
He was also near the top for moving the ball forward through his passing, so he wasn't only a final-third player he helped build attacks too.

Carrying the ball and pressing
He carried the ball forward well and worked hard without it, pressing opponents more than most. Solid in both, even if these weren't where he stood out most.

Takeaway for Coaches
Griezmann is your chance creator. Play him between the lines, give him the ball in the final third, and surround him with finishers; his job is to manufacture the chances, and based on the evidence supported by the data, no one did it better.

Griezmann's creation (per 90 minutes) vs other midfielders



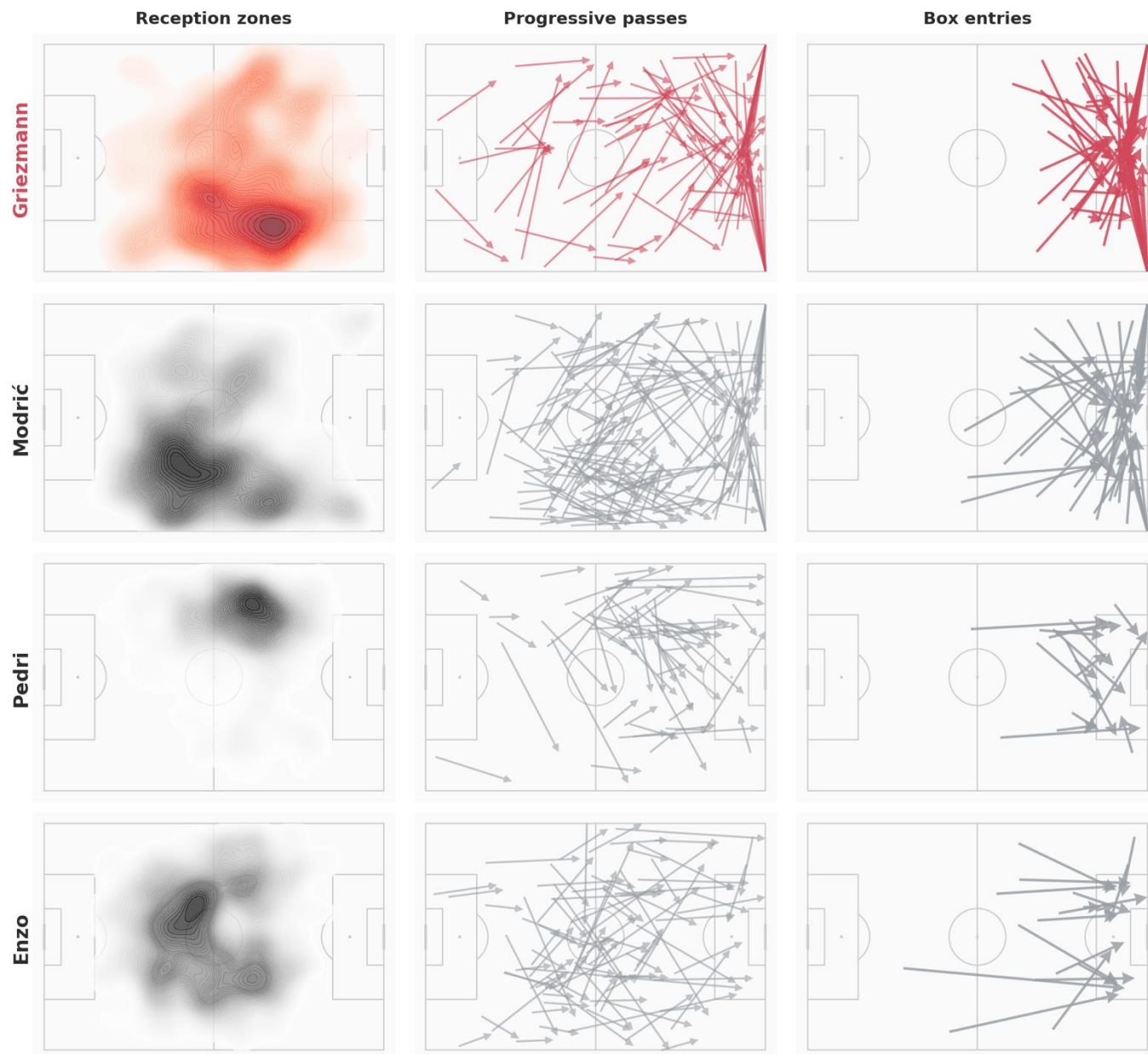
Red = Griezmann. Per 90 from minutes derived per player match (excludes shootouts)

Against three of the tournament's most-used deep creators, Griezmann was unremarkable at moving the ball forward 14.9 progressive passes per 90, well below Modrić's 21.6.

But on passes into the box, he led the group outright at 8.4 per 90, ahead of Modrić (6.4), Pedri (3.9) and Enzo (2.5)

The gap between those two metrics *is* his profile: he does not progress the ball more than his peers, **he finishes the progression more dangerously**. Where Modrić recycles and switches play to keep Croatia moving, and Enzo connects circulation from deep, Griezmann's touches end in the danger zone.

The shape of Griezmann's contribution vs. other midfielders



Where he received the ball (left column)

Griezmann's heat sits high and central right on the edge of the attacking third, between the opposition's midfield and defense. Compare him to the others: Modrić and Enzo pick up the ball deeper, further from goal. Pedri drifts to one side. Griezmann is the one operating closest to the danger area. That's a forward dropping into a creator's pocket, not a deep midfielder.

How he moved the ball forward (middle column)

His passing arrows fan out across the whole attacking half and drive toward goal from many angles. It's a busy, varied picture showing he progressed play from all over, not just one channel.

His Passes into the box (right column)

This is the clearest difference. Griezmann's arrows pour into the penalty area in a dense cluster far more, and far more concentrated, than any of the three below him. Where the others put the occasional ball in, his deliveries flood the box. This is the picture behind his chance creation: a constant supply line into the most dangerous part of the pitch.

Takeaway for Coaches

Griezmann receives higher up than a typical midfielder and turns that position into a stream of passes into the box. He's not a deep playmaker who starts moves; he's the man in the pocket who finishes them off with the final pass. Give him the ball near the area and let him feed the strikers.

Appendix : Metrics & Limitations

How the metrics are defined

1. **Passes into the box:** passes that end inside the penalty area having started outside it.
2. **Progressive passes / carries:** actions that move the ball at least 10 (pass) or 5 (carry) meters closer to the opposition goal, measured as the reduction in straight-line distance to goal.
3. **Pressures:** events where the player actively closed down an opponent in possession (a measure of defensive work rate, not of winning the ball).
4. **Expected assists (xA):** the key creative metric. Each pass in StatsBomb data that leads to a shot carries a link to that shot. xA sums the quality of those shots (their expected goals value) for every chance a player created. A high xA means a player's passes produced genuine shooting opportunities; hopeful passes that lead nowhere score zero. This is what separates "puts the ball in the box a lot" from "creates real chances."

Limitations

1. **Small sample:** Six and a half matches is a short window. A top ranking can be influenced by one or two exceptional chances created, so the percentiles are best read as a *strong indication rather than a settled, season long verdict*.
2. **Team effects:** Griezmann played in one of the tournament's strongest attacks. Some of his creative output reflects the quality of the teammates finishing his passes, not his contribution alone.
3. **Box entries are unweighted:** A floated cross and a cut back to the penalty spot count equally as "passes into the box"; only the xA metric accounts for how dangerous each delivery actually was.
4. **Reception zones are approximate:** The heatmaps show where each player's on-ball actions occurred, which closely tracks but is not identical to where they received passes.

Appendix : Technical Details

Data source

All figures and statistics are derived from StatsBomb's freely available event data for the 2022 FIFA World Cup (competition_id = 43, season_id = 106), covering all 64 matches. The data was ingested using the [mplsoccer](#) library's [Sbopen](#) parser which returns StatsBomb's match, event, lineup, and 360 tracking data as flat tabular frames

Storage & Processing

Data was loaded into a local [DuckDB](#) database (chosen because it executes aggregations directly against the stored data without loading the full dataset into memory and allows a SQL interface ([local duck ui](#)) for inspection and running queries in a notebook fashion (similar to jupyter)

The pipeline follows a layered ([medallion](#)) design architecture:

1. The initial raw layer holding the parser output
2. a cleaned layer applying type and null normalization
3. a feature layer adding derived analytical columns
4. an aggregate layer producing player, team and match level summary tables

Each layer is persisted as its own set of tables and rebuilt independently, so a change at one stage never requires re-pulling the source data

Tech Stack

IDE: [Positron](#)

Database: Duckdb

Programming Languages: Python, SQL